

Academic Writing & Assignment

Week One: Lesson Two



THE LONDON SCHOOL
OF ECONOMICS AND
POLITICAL SCIENCE ■

Overview



- Introductions
- Thesis statements
- Conclusions
- Introductions & conclusions

- Every essay needs an introduction. These give the reader their first impression of your essay and so are very important.
- Essays generally contain three elements or 'moves' (the order of the moves can vary):
 - a) **Academic/Real World Context:** what is the question asking you to focus on and why is this interesting/relevant/important? Consider referring to relevant academic literature to identify a gap/issue/problem/question that needs to be discussed
 - b) **Providing your thesis:** what is your answer to the essay question? This should be as concise as possible and should present a clear argument or position, not just say what you are going to do in the essay.
 - c) **Indicating your approach:** how are you going to structure/frame your answer? What sources/theories/concepts/examples/cases are you going to utilise in your answer?

Introduction Length



Most introductions account for about 10% of the total essay so your introduction for your assignment essay will be quite a bit longer than the introductions for your timed writing essays.



Language Focus



What tenses have been highlighted and why?

Over the past decade, **there have been** a number of attempts made by scholars of development economics to account for the disparity in the rate of economic growth and the ways in which the growth has been experienced by developing countries around the globe. **This essay will focus** on two factors addressed in some of their arguments as determinant elements in explaining such disparity, namely, institutions and geography. **It will then contend that** while the arguments highlighting the former provide more adequate and cogent explanation when assessed individually, one should be wary of the observed causal link between the institutions and economic growth, as the nature of the institutions is conditioned by the context in which they exist. *(118 words) Student essay, used with permission.*

What tenses have been highlighted? Why have these tenses been used?



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**PRESENT
PERFECT**

SIMPLE FUTURE

Present Perfect



Use the present perfect to describe an action that started in the past, but has not yet been completed. It is a common tense to use in the first sentence as it allows you to review what research has been done up to now and/or what relevant events have occurred.

*Over the past decade, **there have been** a number of attempts made by scholars of development economics to account for the disparity in the rate of economic growth and the ways in which the growth has been experienced by developing countries around the globe.*

Simple Future



Use the simple future to talk about an action that will begin and end in the future

***This essay will focus** on two factors addressed in some of their arguments as determinant elements in explaining such disparity, namely, institutions and geography.*

***It will then contend that** while the arguments highlighting the former provide more adequate and cogent explanation when assessed individually, ...*

What tenses have been highlighted? Why have these tenses been used?



These sentences could also have been written using the present simple:

This essay will focus on ...

This essay focuses on....

It will then contend that ...

It then contends that...

Use of first person 'I' versus third person 'This essay'



This essay will focus on ... I will focus on

This essay focuses on.... I focus on

It will then contend that ... I will contend that

It then contends that... I then contend that

All of the above forms are acceptable in current academic writing; however, the use of 'I' is less common in departments where assignments have a numerical basis (Economics, Accounting, Finance etc.)

Thesis Statements



A thesis statement:

- directly answers the question asked of you
- is usually in the introduction (and repeated in the conclusion)
- is specific and focused

Common problems



1. The non-thesis thesis
2. The overly broad thesis
3. The no structure thesis

The non-thesis thesis



Bad Thesis: This essay will consider the advantages and disadvantages of limiting free speech.

Better Thesis: This essay will argue that, while there may be advantages to restricting “hate speech”, the danger of restricting open dialogue on crucial racial issues is too great and too high a price to pay.

The writer adopts a clear position and briefly explains their view

The overly broad thesis



Bad Thesis: The government has the right to limit free speech.

Better Thesis: This essay contends that the government has the right to limit free speech in cases of overtly racist or sexist language **because** our failure to address such abuses would effectively suggest that our society condones such ignorant and hateful views.

The writer is specific and provides justification for their position

The 'no structure' thesis



Bad Thesis: There are many reasons we need to limit hate speech.

Better Thesis: This essay will assert that among the many reasons hate speech should be limited, the most compelling are a)...b)...and c)...

The writer provides a more detailed thesis that indicates how the essay is going to be organised.

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Conclusions



Most conclusions contain these 'moves':

1. A summary of the main points of the essay (but not the whole essay)
2. A re-statement of your main thesis
3. The implications your argument has for the wider field (policy/practice)
4. Recommendations for future research